

was never dull, any aspect of culture was easily available to everyone, anywhere. I was an idiot to think things would stay that way forever.

Pandora's box

The biggest problem that the internet caused was to expose people to other people. Ideas are contagious, (aren't they?) and ignorance really is bliss, because as long as people were unable to see how the rest of the world lives, everything was fine and dandy. Soon internationally accepted principles of right and wrong formed part of our global conscience. Excreta and fan were destined to meet. Governments were overthrown, coups were coordinated using social media, and it didn't matter if CNN or BBC were able to cover it or not, Twitter and Facebook were good enough.

Governments were shaken, and not just dictatorships and monarchies, but all governments. How dare these young upstarts of average intelligence come together and start deciding what's right for them? Why, that's just not the democratic way at all, is it? Next they'll want to start choosing governments, or worse, actually want to vote... the rascals!

Crossing the line

Here in my country we claim to be a democracy, yet dare you voice your opinion against someone in power, and the wrath of a fanatical following of thugs will ensure that you are silenced. However, the Internet was always a safe place to vent. It was all anonymous, and quite safe, until social networking changed all that of course. I suppose my biggest mistake was to use my

LEGALESE

"No specific section in the IT Act entitles a person to sue the government or ISPs for blocking access to legal content. In such cases, however, freedom of speech and expression is our fundamental right guaranteed under Art.19 of the Constitution of India and it is our constitutional right to seek legal redress for its protection by approaching the court."

Cyberlaw expert Karnika Seth

"If access is locked to my content on the web (say by blocking sites such as Vimeo or Blogspot for instance), I would file an appeal against the John Doe order in the higher court or to the division bench of High court if earlier order has been passed by single bench of the same High court. These provisions are there for any citizen in Procedural Law of India. The IT Act, 2000 need not be invoked."

Advocate Prashant Mali, President Cyber Law Consulting.

full name in my email address, and also put my actual details into my accounts. Who would have thought that forwarding a simple cartoon would get me thrown in jail, slapped, humiliated and more. Next it was this Chennai-based company called Copyrights Labs that got the Madras High Court to pass an order using my name! They actually wanted a "John Doe" order to stop just about anyone from accessing video hosting

DID YOU KNOW?

John Doe order was a common name that was seen across all sections of the media couple of months back. This article tries to explain it. <http://goo.gl/ICCiF>

web sites, file sharing sites, and more. Why? Because they were releasing a couple of movies that they wanted to eke every last penny of profit out of. In the end it's all about the money, isn't it? I'm just a nobody, as I said in the start, and I don't have the might to stand in court against big companies. Thankfully, some good samaritans appealed on my behalf, and the whole country doesn't have to suffer for my torrent fetish. ISPs are only supposed to block actual URLs where the content is located, and not entire domains themselves. However, I still cannot get into some video sites from some cities / ISPs. That will change soon, I hope.

Now what?

Now nothing, I wait and watch. According to Google, the Government of India has made over 2000 requests to pull down content that it considers defamatory, inciting violence, or just otherwise unlawful. Since I'm not privy to the details of the requests, I don't know how many of these were child pornography or terrorism propaganda. Not a lot I suspect. I soon learnt about Anonymous, a hacker / wannabe combine that threatens governments who do not toe the line of democracy. Block torrent sites, will you? There you go, insignificant-government-site-that-no-one-visits. You're hacked! Hah! We pwned u, lolz! Then there was an actual physical meeting / protest against the government scheduled in major cities. I thought hundreds, maybe thousands would show up... only 30 did. All of them young, some speaking to the media and proclaiming that it was their right to download movies! The shame! Look, I'm a pirate, and as I mentioned earlier, I truly believe that it helps more than it hurts... but I'm not dumb enough to demand my right to do something illegal! Besides, did anyone really stop downloading anything during the short time that sites were blocked? I also don't get the hactivism thing. To protest against a law that you disagree with by breaking a completely different law seems like breaking down statues in parks because a pigeon did its business on you when you were a kid. If we hate being blocked, find ways around it and publicise, or run proxies that help the general public bypass the blocks... that would be cool in my opinion. To my limited intellect, I just don't see anyone with the correct answers. Oh well, maybe one of you reading this will have some better ideas... let me know! 

INTERNET CENSORSHIP CASES, A TIMELINE

2003	Acting on CERT-In recommendations, the government asked all ISPs to block the Yahoo! Groups' webpage of a Khasi militant group. Instead the ISPs ended up blocking Yahoo! Groups itself.
2006	Blogger, Geocities and Typepad domains were blocked by ISPs instead of blocking objectionable content.
2007	Orkut formed a pact with the Cyber Crime Cell not only to block defamatory content but also share IP addresses from where objectionable content was being produced.
2009	Savitabhabhi.com – an adult comic website was blocked by the government.
2011	Several file-hosting websites were blocked by ISPs based on a John Doe order from a Delhi court.
2012	Cartoonsagainstcorruption.com, a satirical cartoon website was taken down. Sites such as Vimeo, Dailymotion and several torrents sites were blocked.